

The Coffee Consulting Idea

Market analysis — good, bad, and ugly Prepared 4 September 2026 · Washington State

The one-line verdict

Your diagnosis is right, the market exists, and the business as you've described it does not scale. Selling craft coaching to individual coffee stands is a job you buy for yourself — a hard one, with a cheap customer, a free competitor, and a ceiling around \$80–120k each. But underneath the idea there are two versions that *do* scale, and one of them is a route business almost identical in shape to the one already running.

Read the whole thing before you decide, because the reason it doesn't work is not the reason you'd expect.

1. Is your diagnosis actually correct?

Yes — and be careful with that, because being right is the trap here.

Grind (dose, distribution, dial-in) and milk texture (stretch phase vs. straight steaming) are genuinely the two biggest levers on drink quality behind the bean itself. Most stands do steam without stretching, most run a grinder that hasn't been dialed since the last bean delivery, and most are pulling shots outside any sane extraction window. You are not imagining it.

Two cautions before that becomes a business plan:

Caution 1 — you learned on two setups, not two hundred. One of you on cheap gear, one on pro gear, is a good spread of two. It is not a repeatable method. There's a real difference between *"I can make excellent coffee"* and *"I can make an 18-year-old earning \$17 an hour produce a consistent drink at 7:05am on a Tuesday with six cars in line and no supervisor."* The second one is the product. The first one is a hobby with an audience.

Caution 2 — the customer's palate is the actual variable. More on this in the ugly section, because it's the whole ballgame.

2. Does this already exist?

Yes. Extensively. And it exists in three distinct tiers that all attack you from different directions.

Tier 1 — The direct competitors (paid consultants and academies)

These are exactly the business you described, and several are in your backyard.

PROVIDER	WHERE	WHAT THEY CHARGE
Seattle Barista Academy	Seattle	Barista training \$1,050/day ; store evaluation \$1,200/day ; hourly consult \$580 (4-hr min); bar design \$1,295 ; concept/brand \$2,500
Bellissimo Coffee Advisors	Portland, OR	Consulting products \$250–\$1,125 ; 32+ years, thousands of shops trained
Texas Coffee School, Royal Coffee, Barista Source, Opo, Coffee Shop Success	National	Startup packages, on-site training, operations manuals
Independent consultants (general market)	National	\$75–150/hr, \$500/day typical floor, on-site travel days billed around \$525/day , project work \$3,000–12,000, retainers \$2,500–5,000/mo

Read that Seattle line again. Seattle Barista Academy is charging \$1,050 a day for the exact service you're describing, twenty minutes from most of your prospects, with a school, a brand, and a decade of reputation. That is your comp — and notice who they target: *new shop owners, pre-opening*. Not existing stands. There's a reason for that, and it's in section 5.

Tier 2 — The free competitor (this is the important one)

Every wholesale roaster gives barista training away for free. Caffè Vita, US Roast, Red Rock, Tapestry, Driven — the list is every regional roaster in the state. It is a standard, expected line item in a bean contract: *sign with us, we train your staff*.

This is the single largest structural problem with the idea. Your prospect does not have an unmet need with no supplier. Your prospect has a supplier they don't pay, who shows up when asked, and who is contractually motivated to keep them happy. **You are not selling into a vacuum. You're selling against free.**

The counter-argument exists and it's worth knowing, because it's the pitch you'd have to make: one operator (Coffee Shop Success) publishes a breakdown arguing free roaster training actually costs a shop about **\$396 per hire** in the two-week wait for a training slot — coordination time, milk and espresso

waste, lost productivity at reduced capacity — which lands near **\$4,000/year** for a shop hiring 8–10 people, and that trainees retain only 60–70% of a single 2–3 hour session anyway.

That's a good argument. It is also, notably, an argument being made by someone who already built the scalable version of your business (see Tier 3). The fact that the strongest case against your competitor has already been written and monetized by someone else should tell you where you're entering the timeline.

Tier 3 — The productized competitor

Coffee Shop Success sells **Essential Barista Training** at **\$49/month for unlimited trainees** — a 12-hour on-demand curriculum, available instantly, no scheduling. SCA runs formal certification at **\$1,450–\$4,200** per person for Barista Skills Professional.

So the price ladder in this market already runs from **\$49/month** to **\$4,200/head**, and it's fully occupied at every rung. There's no empty shelf.

3. The market — how big is it really

This is the good news section, and it's genuinely good.

Washington is the second-most coffee-dense state in America. Over **4,000 coffee shops, 57.3 per 100,000 residents** — more than double the national median of 27.3. Only Alaska is denser. Seattle alone holds roughly 278–371 shops depending on how you count, one coffee business per ~2,300 people.

Now cut it down to what you could actually sell to:

LAYER	COUNT	REASONING
All WA coffee shops	~4,000	KNOWN
Less Starbucks	~700	KNOWN — corporate, unsellable
Less other chains (Dutch Bros, Black Rock, Human Bean, Peet's, Dunkin', 7 Brew)	~300–500	ESTIMATE — franchise systems have mandated training
Addressable independents + small multi-unit	~2,800–3,000	ESTIMATE
Within a workable drive of Puget Sound	~1,700–1,900	ESTIMATE — the corridor holds most of the density

So call the serviceable market **~1,800 stands and cafés**. That's a real number and it's bigger than most local service niches.

Then apply reality: cold outreach into owner-operated food service converts in the low single digits. **At 3%, that's ~55 clients you will ever sign**. At an \$1,800 average engagement, that's about **\$100,000 of one-time revenue — total, spread across several years of hustle**. Then you have to go find them again, because you already fixed them.

That is the shape of the problem. The TAM is real; it's just a one-time-sale TAM, and one-time-sale TAMs are small no matter how many logos are in them.

4. The money — what this pays you

Let's be concrete. Two of you, charging at the low end of the local comp (\$800–1,200/day, undercutting Seattle Barista Academy's \$1,050).

Best realistic case, year two, both working it hard:

- Billable days per person: ~90–110/year (the rest is selling, driving, admin — consulting is roughly half delivery, half hunting)
- 100 days × \$1,000 = **\$100,000 gross per person**
- Less travel, fuel, insurance, gear, marketing, self-employment tax
- **Net: roughly \$60–75k each**

For that you get: no recurring revenue, no equity value, income that stops dead the day you stop driving, and a customer you have to replace every time you succeed.

That's not a scalable business. That's a well-paid trade you'd both be doing on top of your existing lives.

The honest comparison: a single drive-thru stand doing \$1,500–2,000/day grosses \$550–730k/year (best-case figure from one industry source — treat as ESTIMATE; most stands do far less). Even at a thin 5–7% net, the operator you're consulting to may out-earn the consultant. Worth sitting with.

5. The bad

Your buyer is broke. Independent coffee shop net margins run **2.5–7%**. Between **50% and 74% of independent shops fail within five years**. In 2026 specifically: Starbucks closed 400 locations in

2025, Peet's shuttered two dozen in San Francisco, Compass Coffee filed Chapter 11 and closed 10. Barista wages went from \$12–14/hr in 2020 to \$15–18/hr in 2026. Bean costs are at records. **You are proposing to walk into that room and ask for \$1,200 to improve something the owner does not currently believe is broken.**

The pain you're solving isn't the pain they feel. Ask any stand owner their top three problems and you'll get: staffing, labor cost, and rent. You'll never get "milk texture." Nobody buys a solution to a problem they haven't ranked.

You have to insult them to open the sale. The pitch is structurally "*your coffee is bad.*" To an owner-operator, their coffee is *them*. This is the hardest cold-open in service selling and it has no easy fix — every version of the pitch that softens it also removes the reason to buy.

There's no moat. Your entire IP is three techniques that are free on YouTube in higher production quality than you'll ever film. Nothing stops a client from having one barista learn it and teach the rest — which is exactly what will happen, and it's the *good* outcome, because it means it worked.

Consulting punishes success. Fix a stand properly and you've eliminated your own customer. Recurring revenue in this model requires either turnover (which exists — food service churns constantly) or a service they consume rather than learn. Training is learned. That's the wrong side of the line.

The delivery model burns people out. Industry write-ups on coffee consulting specifically flag scope creep, unpaid emotional labor, travel, and last-minute demands — one consultant took a two-year hiatus from burnout. As the trade press put it: "*Burnout in consulting isn't about a lack of resilience. It's what happens when overextension becomes the business model.*"

6. The ugly

This is the part that decides it, so here it is undiluted.

Quality is not what sells coffee in the Pacific Northwest drive-thru market

The customer at 6:50am ordering a 20oz caramel breve with six pumps of syrup, whole milk and extra whip **cannot detect your improvements and is not paying a premium for them.** Sugar, fat and temperature mask the entire range between a bad shot and a good one. That is not a cynical take — it's the reason the flavored-drink drive-thru model exists and dominates this specific region.

What actually drives a stand's revenue: **location, drive-thru throughput, speed of service, the barista's personality, hours, and loyalty punch cards.** 7 Brew's whole pitch is double lanes and speed. The stands winning in WA are winning on convenience and vibe.

So the brutal framing: **you would be selling a craft fix into a convenience market.** You'd be right about the coffee and wrong about the business.

This is testable and you must test it before spending a dollar. If a stand can't measure a revenue lift from better coffee, you have no ROI story — and with no ROI story you're selling pride. Pride has a very low price ceiling and no repeat purchase.

The three ways this idea usually dies

1. **The roaster kills it.** "Our roaster does that for free." You get one sentence to counter it, at the door, cold. Most conversations end here.
2. **The owner agrees with you and doesn't buy.** "You're totally right, we should do that" — and then nothing, forever, because it's not in the top three problems.
3. **You succeed and it doesn't compound.** Twelve happy clients, no recurring revenue, no asset, no exit, and a calendar that empties the moment you stop driving to stands.

And the small one that stings

You're both good at coffee. That's the reason you'd start this and it's the least relevant fact about whether it works. Craft skill is the *input*; distribution, recurring billing, and a buyer with money are the business. Being the best barista in the room has almost no correlation with owning the best coffee business in the room — which is, ironically, the exact thing you'd be telling your clients.

7. Is it scalable? Where each rung breaks

RUNG	MODEL	BREAKS AT
1	The two of you, on-site, hourly/day rate	~\$150–200k combined gross. Ceiling is your calendar. Not scalable.
2	Hire and train other consultants	Quality control. Your entire value is craft judgment — the hardest thing to hire for cheaply. Margin per consultant is thin and turnover kills you. Barely scalable.
3	Productize into a course or subscription	Genuinely scalable — but already occupied at \$49/month , and you'd be a late entrant with no audience. Content businesses are won on distribution, not on content quality. Scalable, but you're behind.
4	Sell to roasters instead of stands (B2B2B)	Scalable. One sale reaches 30–80 accounts. See below.
5	Attach recurring service to the training	Scalable, and it's a route business. See below.

8. The two versions I'd actually build

Option A — Become the outsourced training arm for regional roasters

Every roaster in Washington promises free barista training in their wholesale contracts. Almost none of them want to deliver it. It's a cost center staffed by whoever's least busy, it pulls their coffee lead out of the roastery, and it's the first promise that quietly slips when they're busy — which is exactly why that \$396-per-hire waiting-cost argument exists.

So sell it to them, not to their customers. You become the training the roaster promises. They keep the relationship and the bean contract; you get paid per session or on a monthly retainer per account.

Why this is the strongest structural move:

- **One sale reaches 30–80 stands.** The distribution problem is solved in a single conversation.
- **The roaster has money.** They have margin, contracts, and a real budget line. Your prospect stops being a broke stand owner.
- **The objection becomes your channel.** "Our roaster does that for free" — yes, and we're who they send.
- **It's warm every time.** You show up as the roaster's partner, not a stranger criticizing their coffee.

- **It's recurring by nature.** New accounts and staff turnover mean a permanent stream, not a one-time fix.

Downside: fewer, larger customers means concentration risk, and roasters are price-sensitive on a cost center. But this is where I'd start.

Option B — Training as the door, service contract as the business

Here's the thing worth noticing: **the grind problem is a machine problem.** Burrs wear. Grinders drift. Water chemistry ruins extraction and scales the boiler. Nobody dials in daily. That's not a knowledge gap you fix once — it's a maintenance gap that reopens every single week.

The espresso service market already prices this: preventive maintenance visits at **\$150–400**, service contracts at **\$500–2,000+/year**, managed plans at **\$100–300/month**.

So: free or cheap training gets you in the door and proves you know coffee. What you actually sell is a **monthly calibration and maintenance route** — dial-in, burr check, water filter, backflush, PM, staff refresh. Call it \$200/month.

- $60 \text{ stands} \times \$200/\text{mo} = \text{\$12,000 MRR} / \text{\$144k a year}$
- $150 \text{ stands} = \text{\$30,000 MRR}$
- Route density in the Puget Sound corridor is unusually good — 57.3 shops per 100k people is the densest ground in the lower 48
- **It's an asset.** Recurring service contracts have enterprise value. Consulting days do not.

And it is structurally the same business as a route-based service company: dense recurring stops, scheduled visits, a technician who can be trained and equipped, and revenue that doesn't stop when you do. That playbook is already known in the family.

The one honest caveat: this requires actual espresso machine technical skill — plumbing, boilers, electrical, parts sourcing. That's a real apprenticeship, not a weekend. If neither of you wants to become a tech, Option B means hiring one, and that changes the startup cost materially.

Ranked recommendation: A first (cheap to test, no new skills), **B second** (bigger, slower, needs a tech), and treat pure day-rate consulting only as the paid research phase that gets you into 20 stands.

9. Test it in 30 days for under \$500

Do not build a website. Do not register anything. Do not print cards.

Weeks 1–2 — 20 stands, in person, buy a drink at each. Score every drink on the same three-line card (grind/extraction, milk texture, temperature). Ask the person at the window two questions: *"Who trains your baristas?"* and *"What's the hardest part of the job right now?"*

Track only:

- What % say "our roaster"
- How many volunteer a problem that isn't staffing or cost
- Your own quality scores — is the failure rate really as high as you think, measured rather than remembered

Week 3 — offer 10 of them a free 90-minute fix session. No pitch, no upsell. The metric is *how many say yes to free*. If fewer than half say yes to free, nobody will ever say yes to \$1,200 — and you have your answer for the price of some coffee.

Week 4 — two conversations that decide it.

1. Ask three of the free-session stands to pay **\$500** for a follow-up. Any yes is signal. Zero yeses is the answer.
2. Call **three regional roasters** and ask a single question: *"Would you pay us to deliver the barista training you promise your wholesale accounts?"* That's the Option A test, and it's one phone call each.

Decision rule — set it now, before you're emotionally invested:

- 3+ roasters interested → **build Option A.**
- 0 roasters, but stands paying \$500 → **you have a real trade; work out whether that's the job you want.**
- Nobody pays and roasters shrug → **the market is telling you it's not paying for quality. Believe it and move on.**

Total cost: gas and about forty drinks.

10. What I actually think

The instinct is good. You've correctly identified a real, widespread, fixable quality failure in a market that is unusually dense, in a region where coffee is culturally central. That's a legitimate starting observation, and most business ideas don't have one.

But the business you described — two skilled guys driving to stands to teach craft — is the least valuable way to monetize that observation. It has a broke customer, a free incumbent competitor, no moat, no recurring revenue, no asset at the end, and a hard ceiling at roughly the income of a good trade job. And it carries a genuine existential risk: the possibility that better coffee doesn't actually make a drive-thru stand more money, in which case there is no ROI story to sell at any price.

The scalable version isn't teaching coffee. It's owning the recurring relationship that keeps the coffee good — either by becoming the roasters' training arm, or by turning the grind problem into a monthly calibration and maintenance route across the densest coffee ground in the country.

Run the 30-day test. It costs almost nothing and it will either kill the idea or sharpen it inside a month. And it answers the only question that matters — which isn't "*is their coffee bad?*" (you already know it is) but "**will anyone pay to fix it?**"

Sources

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- Seattle Coffee Scene — starting a drive-thru coffee stand: <https://seattlecoffeescene.com/how-to-start-a-drive-thru-coffee-stand/>

Figures marked ESTIMATE are reasoned from the sources above, not measured. Revenue and conversion math is illustrative — treat it as a model to argue with, not a forecast.